FIELD PLAYBOOK | AGRI-SERVICES | 2026-27

The Kisan Drone Business Playbook 2026-27

How to start and run a drone spraying service in India: the subsidy that pays for half the machine, the licence that makes it legal, the spray numbers that keep farmers coming back, and the acreage you need before the EMI stops hurting.

INSIDE

- The exact SMAM 2026 subsidy slabs, and the four documents that decide your file
- The Rs 2,000 per hectare demand subsidy that quietly pays your customer's bill
- Drone Rules 2021 in plain English: UIN, remote pilot certificate, green zone, insurance
- A full unit-economics model: capex, per-acre cost, break-even acres, 12-month cash flow
- Ten printable worksheets, a 30-day launch plan and 25 answers to real objections

Written for India. Every figure traced to a government notification, a PIB release or a DGCA rule, with the date it was checked.

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NOVEMBER 2026

Before you spend a rupee

A drone spraying business in India is not a gadget purchase. It is a service business with a licence attached, a subsidy that takes months to arrive, and a customer who judges you on one spray and never calls again if it goes wrong. This book treats it that way.

Three things are true at once in late 2026. The machine has become affordable: a workable 16-litre spray drone is listed by Indian dealers at roughly Rs 4 lakh, not the Rs 10 lakh it cost three years ago. The government is paying a large share of that cost through SMAM and Namo Drone Didi. And the farmer's side of the bill is being subsidised too, at Rs 2,000 per hectare in low-mechanisation districts, which means the person you want as a customer is being handed money to hire exactly the service you are selling.

That combination does not stay open forever. Subsidy windows close, state lists get exhausted, and districts fill up with operators. The operators who do well are the ones who understood the paperwork and the unit economics before they bought, not after.

How to use this book

Read Part 1 and Part 7 first. Part 1 tells you whether your district has demand. Part 7 tells you how many acres a month you need before the machine pays for itself. If either answer is bad, stop and keep your money. If both are good, work through Parts 2 and 3 in order, because the subsidy file and the licence run on government time, not your time, and they should start before the drone arrives.

The worksheets in Part 11 are designed to be printed or filled on a phone. They are plain tables, not software. A notebook works.

> **What this book will not do**
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> It will not tell you that a drone business is easy, that subsidies arrive quickly, or that every village has work. It will not quote a profit figure as if it were guaranteed. Every rupee figure below is either taken from a government document or labelled as a planning assumption you should replace with your own quote.

Contents

	Section	What it covers
Part 1	**The market you are walking into**	Who is already buying, what the government has funded, and the one number that predicts whether a district works
Part 2	**The money: SMAM, Drone Didi and the demand subsidy**	Subsidy slabs, eligibility, the application file, and why so many applications fail
Part 3	**The law: Drone Rules 2021 without the jargon**	UIN, remote pilot certificate, airspace zones, insurance, import, penalties
Part 4	**Choosing the machine**	Tank size, batteries, chargers, transport, and what to demand in the quotation
Part 5	**Spray craft: the numbers that keep customers**	Height, speed, water volume, droplet size, weather windows, calibration, records
Part 6	**Finding customers in a 15 km radius**	Village clusters, pricing, the demo day, FPO tie-ups and the booking system
Part 7	**Unit economics: acres, EMI and break-even**	Capex, per-acre cost, three realistic scenarios, sensitivity and seasonality

	Section	What it covers
Part 8	**Running the operation**	Daily routine, battery logistics, safety, invoicing, maintenance and monsoon survival
Part 9	**Tax, GST and paperwork**	Business form, GST on the drone versus the service, presumptive tax, insurance
Part 10	**Scaling beyond one drone**	Second machine, allied services, hiring pilots, and how to exit cleanly
Part 11	**Ten worksheets**	Eligibility, capex, break-even, pricing, cash flow, pipeline, spray log, maintenance
Part 12	**Answers, sources and a 30-day plan**	Twenty-five real objections, the source list with dates, glossary, launch calendar

PART 1

The market you are walking into

India's drone spraying market is no longer a pilot project. It is a funded, licensed, price-discovered service market with roughly a thousand machines already flying and a subsidy line that pays farmers to hire them.

What has actually been deployed

In February 2026 the government told Parliament that lead fertiliser companies had distributed 1,094 agricultural drones to women self-help groups, of which 500 came through the Namo Drone Didi scheme. Those 1,094 machines are not a national fleet large enough to serve Indian agriculture. They are a proof of concept that has already answered the only question that matters to you: does a farmer pay for drone spraying when it is offered properly? The answer is yes, and the government has now put money behind both sides of the transaction.

What was measured	Figure	Source and date
Drones distributed to women SHGs by lead fertiliser companies	1,094 (as on January 2026)	PIB release, 13 February 2026
Of those, supplied under Namo Drone Didi	500	PIB release, 13 February 2026
Namo Drone Didi outlay	Rs 1,261 crore	PIB, 1 November 2024
Women SHGs to be equipped under the scheme	14,500	PIB, 1 November 2024
Budget provision, Namo Drone Didi	Rs 100 crore (BE 2025-26) rising to Rs 677 crore (RE)	PRS analysis, Demands for Grants 2026-27
Area each equipped SHG is expected to service	2,000 to 2,500 acres a year	Namo Drone Didi operational guidelines
Time to cover one acre, field study of 500 drones	7 to 8 minutes	ADRTC study cited by PIB, 13 February 2026
Flight time on one battery charge	5 to 20 minutes, by manufacturer	ADRTC study cited by PIB, 13 February 2026

Read that last pair of rows together. A machine that covers an acre in seven minutes, flown across a working day with spare batteries, can physically touch 40 to 50 acres. The constraint is never the drone. It is water, chemical, transport, battery charging and whether the farmer next door has been told you exist.

The number that decides your district

Drone spraying demand is not spread evenly. It follows three things: a crop that needs four to eight sprays a season, a labour shortage at exactly those spray dates, and landholdings small enough that the farmer cannot justify owning a machine.

Paddy, cotton and chilli are the classic cases. A paddy farmer in a labour-scarce district sprays four to six times. A cotton farmer sprays eight to twelve times and has watched knapsack spraying costs climb every year. A chilli or vegetable grower sprays even more often and is the easiest first customer, because one skipped spray shows up as visible damage within a week.

The test is simple enough to do from a bike in one afternoon: ride 15 km from your base and count continuous cropped land, note the crop, and ask three farmers what they paid for their last spray and who did it. If the answer is a hired labour pair at Rs 400 to Rs 600 a day who finished two acres, you have a market. If the answer is that everyone sprays their own two acres on a Sunday, you have a hobby, not a business.

The 2,000-acre rule of thumb

Government guidelines expect one equipped SHG to service 2,000 to 2,500 acres a year. Treat that as the realistic annual ceiling for one machine in a good district, not a promise. At Rs 400 an acre that is Rs 8 lakh to Rs 10 lakh of annual billing from one drone. The whole business case fits inside whether you can get to even half of it.

Where the demand subsidy changes the conversation

Under the revised SMAM guidelines of August 2026, small and marginal farmers in low mechanisation regions get Rs 2,000 per hectare for hiring drones from Custom Hiring Centres and women SHGs, up to 2 hectares of owned land a year, paid through DBT after the sprayed area is georeferenced and verified online.

Rs 2,000 a hectare is about Rs 810 an acre. Market rates for drone spraying run roughly Rs 300 to Rs 700 an acre. In the districts where this support is live, the farmer's out-of-pocket cost for a drone spray falls to near zero, and the service becomes the cheapest option on the table rather than a premium one. That is the single strongest sales argument available to you, and almost nobody uses it because most operators have never read the guidelines.

Two conditions follow. First, the payment flows to farmers who hire from a registered Custom Hiring Centre or a women SHG, so being one of those two things is worth real money. Second, the sprayed area has to be georeferenced and monitored, which means your record keeping is not paperwork for its own sake; it is the evidence that releases your customer's subsidy.

Who you are actually competing with

Competitor	What they charge	Where they win	Where you win
Knapsack or manual spraying labour	Rs 400-600 a day for a pair, roughly 2 acres	Familiar, credit-friendly, no booking	Speed, no human contact with chemical, uniform coverage, water saving
Tractor-mounted boom sprayer	Hired by the hour; needs a trampled field and a lot of water	Good on flat, large, row crops	No crop damage, no water logistics, works on small and irregular plots
Namo Drone Didi SHG operator	Often Rs 300-500 an acre, sometimes subsidised further	Backed by the state, cheap, local	Availability, machine size, willingness to work odd hours and remote plots
Other private drone operators	Rs 400-700 an acre	Existing relationships	Response time, records, honest calibration

The SHG operator is not really your enemy. There are 14,500 of them planned against lakhs of villages, and every one of them creates a farmer who has seen a drone spray work. The practical move in most districts is to serve the areas and crops they cannot reach, and to rent capacity to each other in peak weeks.

The honest risks

Four things kill drone service businesses in India, and none of them is technology.

- **Seasonality.** A kharif-heavy district may give you six working months and six months of EMI with no revenue. Part 7 models this properly; do not skip it.
- **Payment delays.** Farmers pay after harvest. Subsidy-linked work pays after verification. You need working capital for diesel, batteries and wages in between.

- **One bad spray.** A drifted herbicide or a wrong dose can destroy a crop and your reputation in the village in the same week. Part 5 exists to prevent this.
- **Regulatory drift.** The Drone Rules are being folded into the Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024, a draft Civil Drone (Promotion and Regulation) Bill was circulated in September 2025, and state SOPs are updated without notice. Check before every season.

PART 2

The money: SMAM, Drone Didi and the demand subsidy

There are three separate pots of public money in this business: one pays for the machine, one pays for the training, and one pays your customer. Most people chase only the first and lose the other two.

Pot one: SMAM pays up to half the machine

The Sub-Mission on Agricultural Mechanization, whose operational guidelines were revised in August 2026, subsidises Kisan Drones under two routes. The rates below are from Annexure-I of those guidelines.

Route	Who	Assistance	Ceiling
Kisan Drone, individual ownership	SC/ST, small and marginal farmers, women, North-East states	50% of cost	Rs 5.00 lakh
Kisan Drone, individual ownership	All other farmers	40% of cost	Rs 4.00 lakh
Kisan Drone Custom Hiring Centre	Agriculture graduates	50% of basic cost of drone and attachments	Rs 5.00 lakh
Custom Hiring Centre (general)	Rural youth entrepreneurs, farmers as entrepreneurs, DAY-NRLM SHGs, FPOs, panchayats, PACS and cooperative societies of farmers	40% of project cost, with each machine capped at the 40% slab	Rs 250 lakh per project
Farm Machinery Bank	Groups and FPOs	80% of project cost up to Rs 30 lakh; 90% for SHGs and FPOs of FRA patta holders	Per-machine cap derived from the 50% slab
North-East region, individual	Farmers and FRA patta holders	100% of machine cost	Rs 1.25 lakh per machine

Two details decide whether your file survives. A Kisan Drone Custom Hiring Centre beneficiary must have passed Class 10 or its equivalent from a recognised board, and must have a trained drone pilot available to operate the machine. A CHC project above Rs 50 lakh has to be sanctioned through the Detailed Project Report route, which is a different and slower process. Applications below that line move through the normal state channel.

How the application actually runs

1. **Check your state's annual plan.** SMAM money is released to states, and each state prepares an Annual Action Plan naming the districts and machines it will fund. If Kisan Drones are not in your district's plan for the year, no amount of paperwork will help. Ask the District Agriculture Officer or the agriculture engineering wing directly.
2. **Register on the state portal.** Most states run applications through the SMAM module on agrimachinery.nic.in or their own agriculture portal. You will need Aadhaar, bank account seeded to Aadhaar, land records where ownership is a condition, and caste or category certificate where a higher slab applies.
3. **Get the machine specification and quotation right.** States empanel manufacturers and models. A quotation for a machine that is not on the empanelled list, or priced above the state's approved ceiling, is the most common reason a file comes back.
4. **Expect selection by draw or district quota, not first-come.** Over-subscription is normal. Applying in the first week of the window matters more than applying well.
5. **Pay your share, then claim.** SMAM is usually a back-ended or reimbursement-linked subsidy. You will be asked to show the invoice, the payment proof and the machine's physical verification before the subsidy lands.

6 **Keep the machine for the lock-in period.** Subsidised machines usually cannot be sold within a defined period. Check your sanction letter; violating this can trigger recovery.

> **The training condition people miss**
>
> CHC beneficiaries are required to have adequate training from a Farm Machinery Training and Testing Institute or another reputed institute in the state, and the guidelines specifically route Kisan Drone skilling through DGCA-authorised Remote Pilot Training Organisations. Budget for the pilot course as part of the project, not as an afterthought. It is also the fastest way to lose a subsidy: a machine with no licensed pilot is a machine the district officer cannot verify as operational.

Pot two: Namo Drone Didi, if you are or work with a women SHG

This is a central sector scheme that gives women self-help groups under DAY-NRLM a fully equipped drone package: the drone, accessories, an anemometer, one year of warranty, two years of annual maintenance and comprehensive insurance. The group pays 20%. The government covers 80% of the package cost, capped at Rs 8 lakh, and the remaining 20% can be borrowed from the Agriculture Infrastructure Fund with a 3% interest subvention.

Two members are trained for 15 days: five days of mandatory drone pilot training and ten days of additional training covering maintenance and use of the machine. Selection runs through the State Rural Livelihood Mission, not through you, and the state picks groups based on local agricultural demand.

If you are not an SHG, this is still relevant to you in two ways. It tells you where your competition and your potential partners are, and it tells you what a fully equipped package contains, which is a useful checklist when you buy your own.

Pot three: the Rs 2,000 a hectare that pays your customer

Component 4.5 of the SMAM guidelines provides financial assistance of Rs 2,000 per hectare to small and marginal farmers in low mechanisation regions for hiring drones from Custom Hiring Centres and women SHGs, limited to 2 hectares of owned land a year, proportionate to actual land owned, and released through DBT.

Question	Answer from the guidelines
Who pays the farmer	The state, through DBT, after the sprayed area is georeferenced and verified
How much	Rs 2,000 per hectare, up to 2 hectares a year (about Rs 810 an acre, up to roughly 5 acres)
Who can the farmer hire	A Custom Hiring Centre or a women SHG, under an MoU signed with the state
What you must produce	Georeferenced area records, monitored online

This is why the CHC registration in Pot one is worth chasing even if your subsidy amount is small. A registered CHC sits inside the pipeline that releases your customer's money, and an unregistered private operator does not.

The taxes on the two halves of the business

The drone itself attracts 5% GST, following the 56th GST Council's recommendation, effective from 22 September 2025. The spraying service is a different question: spraying of agrochemicals on agricultural land has been held to be an exempt support service to agriculture under heading 9986, in a Haryana Authority for Advance Ruling decision involving PI Industries. That does not automatically describe every contract you sign, particularly if you supply the chemical as well as the flight, so get your own structure confirmed by a practitioner

before you assume exemption.

PART 3

The law: Drone Rules 2021 without the jargon

Four things make a spray drone legal in India: a registered machine, a licensed pilot, airspace you are allowed to be in, and insurance. Everything else is detail.

The machine: registration and type certificate

No person may operate an unmanned aircraft system without registering it on the Digital Sky platform and obtaining a Unique Identification Number, unless the rules exempt it. The operator is also responsible for ensuring the machine conforms to a valid type certificate. Manufacturers and importers can generate the UIN themselves through self-certification on the platform, which is why you should buy from a dealer who hands over a UIN-ready, type-certified machine rather than a grey import.

Size classes in the Drone Rules, 2021 run from nano at 250 grams or less, through micro up to 2 kg, small up to 25 kg, medium up to 150 kg, to large above that. The rules were extended to cover machines up to 500 kg. A loaded 10 or 16 litre spray drone sits in the small class.

Import is a separate gate: the Drone Rules leave import of drones to be regulated by the Directorate General of Foreign Trade, and drone imports are restricted. Buying an imported machine without the right licence is a problem that surfaces at registration, which is the worst possible moment.

The pilot: remote pilot certificate

Requirement	What the rules say
Age	Not less than 18 and not more than 65 years
Education	Passed Class 10 or equivalent from a recognised board
Training	Completed the training specified by the Director General at an authorised Remote Pilot Training Organisation
Fee	Rs 100, reduced from Rs 3,000, and delinked from drone size
Validity	10 years
Issue	DGCA issues the licence, normally within 15 days of the certificate from the training organisation

A DGCA-authorised RPTO course is commonly five days: theory covering the Drone Rules, airspace and Digital Sky, simulator work, and field flying, ending with the DGCA examination. Fees are set by the training organisation, not by DGCA, and quotes in 2026 range from about Rs 15,000 at some southern institutes to Rs 50,000 or more where a university runs the course. Ask three, and ask specifically whether the fee includes the DGCA exam, the Digital Sky application and the practical flying hours.

The airspace: green, yellow, red

Indian airspace for drones is mapped into three colours on the Digital Sky platform, and the map is free to view without login. You are required to check it before operating, because boundaries change.

Zone	Where it is	What you need
Green	Up to 400 feet (120 m) above ground, outside red and yellow zones; also up to 200 feet within 8 to 12 km of an airport perimeter	No permission required
Yellow	Above 400 feet in a green zone; above 200 feet within 8 to 12 km of an airport perimeter; other restricted patches	Permission from the concerned air traffic control authority

Zone	Where it is	What you need
Red	No-drone zones, typically near strategic installations and sensitive sites	Permission from the Central Government

The practical implication for a farm operator is small but real. Most farmland sits in the green zone and needs no permission at all. Fields within 12 km of a runway, near a military station or beside a dam need a check first. Do that check once per village cluster and write the result in your records; it takes ten minutes and it is the difference between a normal day and a police complaint.

The safety net: insurance and no-permission-no-takeoff

Part X of the Drone Rules makes third party insurance mandatory for unmanned aircraft systems, applying the Motor Vehicles Act framework to drone operations, with nano drones exempt. The rules also provide for No Permission No Takeoff, real-time tracking beacons and geo-fencing, notified with lead time for industry.

In plain terms: buy a third party liability policy that names drone operations, keep the certificate in the case with the machine, and check that your policy covers chemical drift damage and not just a crash. The maximum penalty for violations under the rules was brought down to Rs 1 lakh, but the cost of an uninsured drift incident into a standing crop is set by the farmer, not by the rules.

What is changing, and what to check each season

Drone regulation in India has been in motion since 2021. The Drone Rules have been amended more than once, and they now operate under the Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024, which replaced the Aircraft Act. A draft Civil Drone (Promotion and Regulation) Bill was circulated for consultation in September 2025; as of late 2026 it has not replaced the existing framework. On the agricultural side, the Department of Agriculture's standard operating procedure for drone application of pesticides, issued under the Insecticides Act framework, sets the technical limits that Part 5 of this book uses.

- Check the Digital Sky airspace map for every new village cluster, every season.
- Check the current CIB and RC list of formulations approved for drone application before buying any chemical, and read the label; the label is the law.
- Keep the UIN certificate, type certificate copy, remote pilot licence, insurance policy and airspace check in one folder in the vehicle. Inspectors ask for the folder, not the story.
- If a new drone bill or amendment is notified, read the transition clause first; it usually tells you how long your existing registration stays valid.

PART 4

Choosing the machine

Tank size decides your customer, your battery bill and your transport. Buy for the work you can actually sell in the next two seasons, not for the brochure.

What a spray drone costs in India right now

Dealer-listed prices in August 2026 put a 5 litre machine at about Rs 3 lakh, a 10 litre at roughly Rs 3.5 lakh, a 16 litre between Rs 4 lakh and Rs 5 lakh, and a 40 litre at Rs 11.5 lakh or more. Imported 25 litre machines are quoted around Rs 12.7 lakh. These are list prices before negotiation and before GST at 5%.

Tank	Typical listed price	Acres per fill (at 25 litres a hectare)	Who it suits
5 litre	about Rs 3.0 lakh	Under 1	Trial plots, horticulture, terrace and nursery work
10 litre	about Rs 3.5 lakh	About 1	Two to ten acre holdings, a first contract machine
16 litre	Rs 4.0 to 5.0 lakh	About 1.6	The default choice for a service business in field crops
40 litre	Rs 11.5 lakh and up	About 4	Contract operators with 100+ acre clients and a pickup

A 16 litre machine is the sensible default. It carries enough to finish a one acre plot without a refill, weighs little enough to move on a bike-mounted carrier or the back of a small pickup, and stays inside the small category. A 40 litre machine halves your refills per acre but needs a vehicle, two people to lift it and a customer base big enough to justify Rs 11 lakh.

The parts of the quotation nobody asks about

1. **Battery count and chemistry.** One battery is not a working set. Field time is 5 to 20 minutes a charge depending on the machine, so you need three or four packs and a charging plan. Ask for the pack price separately; it is the largest recurring cost you will carry.
2. **Charger input.** A field charger that runs off a generator is not the same as a mains charger. Confirm the input voltage range and whether it will run from a 3 kW generator, or you will be charging at home between fields.
3. **Nozzle options.** You need at least two sets: flat fan anti-drift for herbicides and a finer set for insecticides and fungicides. Ask for the droplet spectrum in microns, not the nozzle name.
4. **Pump type and flow rate.** Diaphragm pumps are the norm. Ask for the flow range in litres per minute and confirm it can be turned down to the low volumes drone spraying uses.
5. **Type certificate and UIN support.** The machine must be able to be registered on Digital Sky with a UIN, and the dealer should either do it or show you how. A dealer who has never heard of Digital Sky is selling you a problem.
6. **Service in your district.** Ask for the name and phone number of the nearest service technician, and the price of a replacement arm and a replacement pump. If the answer is a city 400 km away, price that into your risk.
7. **Warranty terms in writing.** Battery warranty is usually shorter than the airframe warranty and is voided by deep discharge. Get the cycle count and the discharge floor in writing.

What not to buy

Do not buy a used machine from a farmer who could not make it work, unless you can verify its UIN, its type certificate and its battery health. Do not buy a grey import without a DGFT import licence; it cannot be registered. Do not buy the cheapest 10 litre on a marketplace listing with no service address in your state, however good the price looks in the first week.

Transport and the rest of the kit

Item	Why	Planning cost
Vehicle	A drone, four batteries, a generator, 60 litres of water and a helper do not fit on a scooter	Rs 2.5-4 lakh used pickup, or hire per day
Generator	Charging between fields, especially where there is no power in the field	Rs 30,000-40,000
Water drum and pump	Most fields have a source; not all have a clean one at the headland	Rs 6,000-10,000
Measuring jugs, pH strips, PPE	Dose accuracy and operator safety	Rs 5,000
Phone with a good camera	Your demo videos and your spray records are the same asset	Already owned

PART 5

Spray craft: the numbers that keep customers

Drone spraying fails for one of three reasons: too little water, the wrong droplet size, or spraying in wind. Get those three right and the machine looks like magic.

The operating window set by the agriculture ministry's SOP

The Department of Agriculture's standard operating procedure for drone application of pesticides, issued under the Insecticides Act framework, fixes the parameters below. State agriculture departments reprint them with small local variations, and the chemical label always overrides both.

Parameter	Setting	Why it matters
Flight height	1.5 to 2.5 m above the crop canopy (higher for tall or lodging-prone crops)	Too low scalds the canopy, too high loses the spray to drift
Flight speed	About 4.5 to 5 m/s	Faster than this thins the deposit per square metre
Spray volume	20 litres per hectare early season, 25 litres per hectare at full canopy	The single most common error is halving this to save time
Droplet size	250 to 350 microns for insecticide and fungicide; coarser for herbicides	Fine droplets drift; coarse droplets bounce
Nozzle	Flat fan anti-drift	Hollow cone and whirl plates are for ground sprayers
Swath width	3 to 6 m depending on height and nozzle	Overlap of about 20% prevents striping
Wind	Under about 3 m/s, and never across a susceptible neighbouring crop	Some state SOPs state 8 km/h; use the stricter figure
Temperature	Below about 35 C	Volatilisation and evaporation losses climb quickly above this
Humidity	Above 50%	Dry air shrinks droplets before they land
Time of day	Early morning or late afternoon	Calm air, open stomata, no heat stress

Two more rules from the same SOP are worth writing on the tank. Keep a buffer strip of at least 20 to 30 metres from houses, water bodies, cattle sheds, apiaries and susceptible neighbouring crops, and never spray a herbicide when the wind is carrying towards a broadleaf crop. Herbicide drift is the fastest way to convert a profitable week into a compensation claim.

Calibration: five minutes that decide the dose

Every crop and every chemical needs the machine set for it. Do this once per tank mix, not once per season.

1. Pick a measured strip: 20 metres long, swath width known.
2. Fill the tank with clean water to a marked level and note the reading.
3. Fly the strip at your working height and speed, spraying as normal.
4. Refill to the mark and measure what you used. Litres used divided by area covered gives your actual litres per hectare.
5. If it is above the label volume, raise speed slightly or reduce flow; if below, slow down or open the flow. Re-check once.
6. Only then add chemical, in the label's order: water first, then wettable powders, then flowables, then emulsifiable concentrates, then adjuvants last.

Write the result in your spray log: date, village, farmer, crop, area, product, dose, water volume, wind, time started and finished. That page is your defence if a farmer claims damage, and it is the evidence that releases a subsidy-linked payment.

Crop notes from the field, not the brochure

Crop	Sprays a season	What the operator must know
Paddy	4 to 6	Spray at the right growth stage, not in standing water wind tunnels between bunds; afternoon convection is strong
Cotton	8 to 12	The best customer in India for drone spraying; watch for whitefly resistance and never mix incompatible products to save a flight
Chilli and vegetables	10 to 15	High value, high frequency, most sensitive to a bad spray; start here to build reputation, charge accordingly
Wheat	2 to 3	Fewer flights, bigger blocks; good for filling a quiet month
Sugarcane	3 to 5	Tall canopy, so fly higher and use the higher water volume
Soybean	3 to 4	Short season, tight spray windows; book early
Horticulture and orchards	6 to 10	Small plots, irregular shapes, good for a 5 or 10 litre machine

Safety, plainly

- Nobody stands under the flight path during a spray, and nobody enters the field for the label's re-entry interval afterwards. Say the interval out loud to the farmer before you leave.
- PPE for the person mixing: gloves, mask, goggles, full sleeves. Mixing is more dangerous than flying.
- Triple-rinse empty containers, puncture them, and take them back. Do not leave them at the field.
- Keep a first aid kit and clean water in the vehicle, and know the nearest primary health centre for the villages you serve.
- Never spray a product that is not on the CIB and RC list approved for drone application, and never exceed the label dose to compensate for a rushed job.

PART 6

Finding customers in a 15 km radius

A spray drone has a working radius set by battery, water and diesel, not by ambition. Win one cluster of five villages completely before you drive to the next taluka.

The first twenty customers

Your first twenty customers are not the poorest farmers and they are not the biggest landowners. They are the ones who already pay for spraying and complain about it: the chilli grower with two acres and a pest problem, the cotton farmer with ten acres and no labour, the input dealer's best customer who buys a full package every season.

1. **List 40 names before you list a price.** From the village input dealer, the KVK, the FPO, the sugar mill's field officer and your own family's contacts. Forty names in a 15 km radius is a day's work and it is the whole top of your funnel.
2. **Run one free demo per village, on a real field, at a real spray time.** Do not demonstrate on an empty plot at noon. Spray a farmer's actual field with his actual chemical, charge him nothing for the first acre, and let him watch the deposit on the leaf. Film it.
3. **Quote in the farmer's unit.** Per acre, not per hectare, not per hour, not per litre. A farmer knows his acreage to the decimal; he does not know what a hectare is.
4. **Book the season, not the spray.** Offer a season package: six sprays at a fixed per-acre rate, paid in two instalments. This is what turns a month of scrambling into a calendar.
5. **Collect a number, not a promise.** Add every farmer you meet to a WhatsApp list with his village and crop. Send one message a week during spray season: the weather window, the pest advisory, your open slots.

Pricing without guessing

The market rate for drone spraying in India sits roughly between Rs 300 and Rs 700 an acre, with the chemical usually supplied by the farmer. Where you land in that range depends on four things: crop value, plot size, distance, and whether the customer is paying from his own pocket or through a subsidy.

Situation	Sensible price	Reasoning
Chilli, vegetable, horticulture plots under 2 acres	Rs 550-700 an acre	High value crop, small plots, more setup time per acre
Cotton, 5 acres or more, within 8 km	Rs 400-500 an acre	The bread and butter job; volume makes it work
Paddy, large blocks, 20 acres or more	Rs 300-400 an acre	Low value crop, high acreage, low setup time
Subsidy-linked work in a low mechanisation district	Rs 400-450 an acre	The farmer's Rs 810 an acre support covers most or all of it
Emergency or out-of-season call, weekend	Rs 700 and above	You are selling availability, not acreage

Never quote per hour. An hourly rate punishes you for being fast, and being fast is the only thing you are selling.

The people who can hand you 200 acres

Who	What they control	How to approach
FPOs and farmer producer companies	Members' aggregated acreage and often a spraying budget	Offer a per-acre rate for the whole membership with one invoice and one monthly report

Who	What they control	How to approach
Input dealers	The farmer relationship and the chemical sale	Give them a referral fee per acre or a fixed rate card they can resell; they keep the chemical margin
Sugar mills, ginning factories, contract farming firms	Large contiguous blocks of one crop	One meeting with the field officer beats fifty farmer visits
KVKs, ATMA and the district agriculture office	Demonstrations, farmer meetings, subsidy pipelines	Offer to demonstrate at their kisan mela; ask to be listed as a service provider
Registered Custom Hiring Centres	Other machines and a farmer queue	Rent their customer list in peak weeks; you bring the drone, they bring the booking

The 90-day customer plan

- Weeks 1 to 2: the 40-name list, the airspace check for each village, and the price card.
- Weeks 3 to 6: eight demos, one per village, filmed, with a fixed per-acre price announced at each.
- Weeks 7 to 9: the season package offer to every demo attendee, plus one meeting each with the FPO, the input dealer and the KVK.
- Weeks 10 to 13: deliver, log every spray, ask every farmer for the name of one neighbour. Referral is the only marketing that works at this scale.

> **The referral line that works**
>
> After the spray, before you take payment: 'If the field looks good in four days, give me the name of one farmer in this village who sprays the same crop.' Then write the name down in front of him. This converts better than any poster, because the farmer is vouching for you with his own reputation.

PART 7

Unit economics: acres, EMI and break-even

This is the part that decides whether you should buy the drone. The model below uses real 2026 prices and one honest planning assumption: that you will not work twelve months a year.

Capital cost

Item	Amount
16 litre spray drone package (drone, one battery, charger)	Rs 450,000
Two spare batteries	Rs 110,000
3 kW portable generator for field charging	Rs 35,000
Nozzle sets, filters, tools, spare arms	Rs 15,000
Remote pilot training for one person	Rs 35,000
Registration, insurance, first-year compliance	Rs 15,000
Total	**Rs 660,000**

Assume the SMAM subsidy is calculated on the drone, its attachments, batteries and charger, which is Rs Rs 575,000 here, at 50% for an eligible category, giving Rs Rs 287,500. Your net investment is therefore Rs Rs 372,500, and everything below is calculated on that number.

> **If the subsidy does not come**
>
> At the 40% slab the subsidy is Rs Rs 230,000 and your net investment is Rs Rs 430,000. If you get no subsidy at all, the net investment is the full Rs Rs 660,000 and every payback figure in this part roughly doubles. Decide before you buy whether the business works without the subsidy; if it does not, you are taking a subsidy-timing risk, not running a business.

Cost of running one acre

Per acre	Amount
Battery charging (electricity or generator fuel)	Rs 20
Transport to fields	Rs 35
Helper or second pair of hands	Rs 45
Water arrangement and filling	Rs 15
Maintenance reserve (nozzles, pumps, filters, arms)	Rs 30
Battery replacement reserve	Rs 65
Consumables, PPE, cleaning	Rs 20
Variable cost per acre	**Rs 230**

At a blended Rs 450 an acre, each acre contributes Rs 220 before fixed costs. Note what is not in this list: the chemical and the water source belong to the farmer. If you start supplying chemical, you have added a trading business with its own licence, margin and credit risk. Do that later, deliberately, not by accident.

Fixed cost each month

Fixed	Amount
Loan repayment on net investment (5 years at 11%)	Rs 8,099
Hull and third party liability insurance	Rs 1,800
Phone, travel, local marketing	Rs 1,200
Vehicle fixed cost (fuel excluded)	Rs 3,000
Fixed cost per month	**Rs 14,099**

Break-even is therefore Rs 14,099 an acre divided by Rs 220 an acre, which is about 64 acres a month. At 20 acres a working day that is 4 working days a month. This is the single most useful number in the book: if you cannot see 4 spray days a month in your district, do not buy the machine.

Three scenarios, with seasonality built in

	Slow start	Working business	Strong season
Acres a month	60	150	250
Working months a year	8	9	9
Acres a year	480	1,350	2,250
Revenue at Rs 450 an acre	Rs 216,000	Rs 607,500	Rs 1,012,500
Contribution after variable cost	Rs 105,600	Rs 297,000	Rs 495,000
Fixed cost for 12 months	Rs 169,189	Rs 169,189	Rs 169,189
Operating surplus	Rs -63,589	Rs 127,811	Rs 325,811
Net investment recovered in	never	2.9 years	1.1 years

The slow start is not a failure, it is the normal first season while you learn the spray craft and build a name. It is survivable because the fixed cost is small and because the subsidy cut the loan in half. The working business is what a competent operator in a decent district achieves by the second season. The strong season assumes one FPO contract or two input-dealer relationships on top of retail work.

Funding the gap

You will need money between paying for the machine and collecting the subsidy. Three routes are worth a conversation with your bank, in this order.

Route	What it is	Ask specifically about
Agriculture Infrastructure Fund	A lending route for post-harvest and agri-service infrastructure, with interest subvention; the Namo Drone Didi guidelines use it for the SHG share at 3% subvention	Whether a drone CHC qualifies in your state, and the subvention paperwork
Agri term loan against the machine	The machine is the collateral; tenure usually 5 to 7 years	Processing fee, whether the subsidy is netted upfront or reimbursed, and the foreclosure clause
Dealer finance	Fastest, most expensive; useful only if a season is starting in three weeks	Effective annual rate, not the monthly instalment, and the penalty for early repayment

Whichever you choose, borrow against the net investment after subsidy, not the gross price, if the bank will structure it that way. A loan on the full Rs Rs 660,000 while you wait for Rs Rs 287,500 of subsidy is the most common way a good season gets eaten by interest.

What moves the answer most

If this changes	The effect	What to do
Price drops to Rs 350 an acre	Contribution falls to about Rs 125, break-even rises above 100 acres a month	Refuse the work, or take it only in blocks above 20 acres where setup time is near zero
You work only 6 months	Fixed cost still runs for 12; the surplus falls by about Rs 84,000	Plan a second crop cycle or an allied service for the off months
Battery life is 18 months, not 24	Add roughly Rs 20 an acre	Buy one fewer spare and one more charger; keep depth of discharge above 20%
You add a second pilot and helper	Add Rs 25,000-35,000 a month, but you can fly 300+ acres	Only after you have refused work twice for want of capacity
You get no subsidy	Net investment doubles, break-even acres stay the same but the loan doubles	Delay the purchase by one season and apply in the next window

PART 8

Running the operation

The difference between an operator who lasts and one who quits is a routine. Not enthusiasm. A routine, written down, followed on a bad day.

The working day

Time	What happens
Previous evening	Confirm tomorrow's bookings on WhatsApp, one message per farmer with the time window and the chemical to keep ready
05:30	Charge all packs overnight; load drone, generator, water drum, PPE, logbook
06:15	Arrive at field one. Airspace check if the village is new. Walk the boundary, note houses, water bodies, neighbouring crops
06:30-09:30	First block. Refill, re-calibrate if the product changed, log each flight
09:30-10:00	Break. Charge packs from the generator. Collect payment for the morning's work
10:00-12:00	Second block or move to the next village
Afternoon	Avoid spraying in peak heat and wind; use the time for bookings, demo visits, repairs, record entry
16:00-18:30	Evening block in calm air, usually the best deposit of the day
Night	Reconcile the log, invoice, charge, wash nozzles, check arms and props for play

Batteries decide your day

Flight time per charge is 5 to 20 minutes depending on the machine, so a 25 acre day is a battery logistics problem before it is a flying problem. Four packs and two chargers is the minimum for a serious day; two packs and one charger is a hobby.

- Never discharge below the floor the manufacturer specifies, and never store packs full or empty.
- Charge at a stable voltage; a generator that sags damages chargers and packs.
- Number your packs and keep a log of cycles. Retire them on cycle count, not on the day they fail.
- Carry packs in a fire-resistant bag, never loose in the vehicle, and never charge unattended overnight.

Records that pay for themselves

You need four registers, and a single notebook with four sections is enough: spray log (date, farmer, village, crop, area, product, dose, water, wind, time), battery log (pack number, cycles, charge times), maintenance log (part, date, cost), and payment log (invoice, amount, mode, date received).

The spray log is not bureaucracy. It is your proof in a damage dispute, your evidence for subsidy-linked work, and the raw material for the only marketing that matters: showing a new farmer exactly what you did on the field next to his.

Getting paid

Farmers pay late because farming pays late. Structure around it instead of fighting it.

1. Take payment on the day for retail work under 5 acres. UPI, on the spot, before you leave.
2. For season packages, take half at booking and half at the third spray.

3. For FPOs and dealers, invoice monthly with the spray log attached and agree 15 days in writing.
4. For subsidy-linked work, confirm in advance who receives the DBT and what proof the state needs; your log is what releases it.
5. Keep a simple receipt book with your GST status printed on it, whatever that status is.

Maintenance and the monsoon

Frequency	Task
Every flight	Props for cracks and play, arms for looseness, nozzles for blockage, tank seal
Every 10 hours	Pump pressure check, filter clean, motor temperature, frame bolt torque
Monthly	Full strip and clean, wiring inspection, firmware update, battery capacity test
Season end	Service by dealer, pack storage at 50%, airframe clean and dry, insurance renewal diary entry

The monsoon is not dead time if you plan it. It is when you service the machine, renew insurance, meet FPOs for the coming season, do the survey and mapping work that farmers pay for in the off months, and train a second pilot so you are not the single point of failure in October.

PART 9

Tax, GST and paperwork

You can run this business as a proprietorship with a current account and a notebook. You cannot run it without a GST position, an insurance policy and a clear answer on whether your service is taxable.

Which business form

Form	When it fits	What it costs you
Proprietorship with Udyam registration	One operator, one or two machines, under Rs 1 crore turnover	Simplest; you and the business are the same legal person, so liability is personal
Partnership or LLP	Two or more operators pooling capital	Shared liability, written deed essential, LLP adds compliance
Farmer Producer Company or cooperative	An FPO applying for CHC or Farm Machinery Bank support	Board, members, audit; slower but unlocks the group slabs
Private limited	You intend to raise money or sell the business	Audit, filings, cost; premature for one drone

Register on Udyam as a micro enterprise whichever form you choose. It costs nothing, takes twenty minutes with Aadhaar and PAN, and it is the document most state subsidy and tender processes ask for first.

GST: two different answers for two different things

- **The drone.** Drones attract 5% GST, following the 56th GST Council's recommendation with effect from 22 September 2025. If you are not registered, this is built into the price you pay and becomes part of your cost.
- **The spraying service.** Spraying of agrochemicals on agricultural land has been held to be an exempt support service to agriculture under heading 9986, in the Haryana AAR ruling in the PI Industries matter. That ruling turned on the service being provided directly to farmers on their land during the pre-harvest period.
- **Where it gets murky.** If you also supply the chemical, do survey or mapping work, hire out the drone with an operator for non-agricultural purposes, or contract with a company rather than a farmer, the exemption may not describe your invoice. Get your own structure confirmed in writing by a practitioner before you assume it.
- **Registration threshold.** Service providers generally register above Rs 20 lakh of turnover, with lower thresholds in special category states. Even below it, registration can be worth it to claim input credit on the drone; that trade-off is a five-minute conversation with your CA, not a guess.

Income tax, kept simple

A proprietorship files a normal return. If your turnover is within the presumptive limits, section 44AD lets you declare a fixed percentage of turnover as profit and skip the detailed books, provided you do not claim the full set of expenses separately. For a capital-heavy first year, depreciation on the drone can make normal books more attractive than presumptive. This is exactly the kind of choice that pays for one hour of a chartered accountant's time in your first year.

Keep three things and the accountant's job becomes cheap: the invoice book, the bank statement, and the maintenance and battery registers from Part 8. Depreciation, repair deductions and the subsidy's tax treatment all depend on those three.

Insurance you actually need

Cover	Why	Rough annual cost
Third party liability for drone operations	Mandatory under Part X of the Drone Rules; covers injury and property damage to others	Rs 8,000-20,000 depending on sum insured
Hull or all-risk cover on the machine	Crash, fire, theft, transport damage; a 16 litre machine is not a cheap replacement	Rs 12,000-25,000
Crop damage or chemical drift extension	The claim you are most likely to face; ask specifically whether drift is excluded	Ask; often an add-on
Personal accident for pilot and helper	Cheap, and the right thing to do	Rs 2,000-5,000

Read the exclusion list before you sign. Most drone policies exclude operation outside the approved airspace, operation by an unlicensed pilot, and chemical damage unless specifically endorsed. Those three exclusions cover the three most likely incidents.

The compliance file that lives in the vehicle

1. UIN certificate from Digital Sky, printed.
2. Type certificate copy for the model.
3. Remote pilot licence of whoever is flying, and the second pilot's if you have one.
4. Insurance policy and the current premium receipt.
5. Airspace zone note for the villages you serve, with the date you checked.
6. GST registration or a declaration of non-registration, whichever applies.
7. Spray log for the current month.

PART 10

Scaling beyond one drone

Scale when you are refusing work, not when you are bored. The sequence below is the order that keeps cash safe.

Add revenue before you add machines

Service	Why it fits	What it needs
Field survey and mapping	Same machine, different payload; demand from FPOs, contractors and land records work	Photogrammetry software, a better camera, a laptop
Direct seeding of paddy	Replaces a labour-heavy operation and is priced per acre like spraying	Seeding attachment and a different calibration
Granular spreading of fertiliser	Fills the gap between spray cycles	Spreader attachment, and care with overlap
Crop insurance loss assessment	Insurers and state agencies need geotagged evidence after weather events	Documentation discipline and a relationship with the agency
Drone-as-a-service for input dealers	They sell the chemical, you fly it, both earn	A rate card and a monthly settlement
Demonstrations for manufacturers and dealers	Paid per event, low acreage, high margin	A good demo script and a projector

Every one of these uses the asset you already own and the licence you already hold. Two of them can carry your fixed cost through the monsoon, which is the real problem with a single-service drone business.

The second machine, and the second pilot

Buy the second drone when you have refused three bookings in a month, not before. By then you know your peak weeks and your per-acre cost from your own log rather than from this book. Buy the same model as the first: shared spares, shared batteries, one training curve.

Hiring a pilot is the harder decision. A licensed pilot costs Rs 15,000 to Rs 25,000 a month in most districts, and needs supervision for the first season because a pilot who has flown a simulator is not an operator who can read a field. Pay a base plus a per-acre incentive, and keep the customer relationship and the money with you.

Exit, resale and the long view

A subsidised machine carries a lock-in; check the sanction letter before you plan to sell. An unsubsidised machine with a clean logbook, a valid UIN and a healthy battery set holds resale value reasonably well, because the buyer is paying for the licence paperwork as much as the airframe. Keep the logbook as if you will sell it one day, because you might.

PART 11

Ten worksheets

Print these, or copy the columns into a notebook. Fill them with a pencil; the numbers will change in your first season and that is normal.

1. Subsidy eligibility check

Answer every line before you visit the agriculture office. Any 'no' is a question for the district officer.

Question	Yes / No	Note

Source of the conditions: SMAM operational guidelines, revised August 2026.

2. Capital cost worksheet

Get written quotations. Do not use brochure prices.

Item	Quoted price	GST	Notes

3. Per-acre cost worksheet

Fill this from your own first month of operations, not from this book.

Cost head	Per acre	Per month	Note

4. Break-even worksheet

Fixed cost divided by contribution per acre gives the acres you must sell each month.

Line	Value

5. Pricing sheet for five customer types

One price per customer type, written down, so you stop negotiating in the field.

Customer type	Acres	Price per acre	Minimum booking

6. Twelve-month cash flow

Seasonality is the risk. Put the monsoon months in first and see whether you survive them.

Month	Acres	Receipts	Payments	Closing balance

7. Customer pipeline

Forty names before you set a price. Update it weekly.

Farmer or FPO	Village	Crop	Acres	Stage	Next action

8. Spray log

One line per job. This is your legal defence and your subsidy evidence.

Date	Farmer	Crop / area	Product and dose	Water / wind	Time

9. Battery and maintenance register

Cycle count, not calendar, retires a pack.

Pack or part	Cycles or hours	Date	Action taken	Cost

10. Season review

Fill this at the end of every season. It is the only document that makes next season better.

Question	Answer

PART 12

Answers, sources and a 30-day plan

Twenty-five questions people actually ask before buying a spray drone, answered without optimism.

Money and subsidy

Question	Answer
Can I get the subsidy if I am not a farmer?	Under the CHC route, yes: rural youth entrepreneurs, SHGs, FPOs, panchayats and PACS are named beneficiaries. The district plan must include Kisan Drones.
How long does the subsidy take?	Plan on three to nine months from application to credit, depending on the state's release of funds. Never plan your cash flow around the subsidy date.
Is the subsidy paid to me or the dealer?	It varies by state. Most routes are back-ended: you pay, then claim. Ask the district office in writing which model your state uses.
Can I buy any drone and claim?	No. The model must be empanelled by the state and priced within the approved ceiling. Buying first and claiming later is how files fail.
Do I need to be an agriculture graduate?	Only for the 50% Kisan Drone CHC slab. The general CHC slab at 40% is open to the wider list of beneficiaries.
What is the one document that most often blocks a file?	A quotation for a non-empanelled model, or a missing Class 10 certificate and trained-pilot proof for the CHC route.

Licence and law

Question	Answer
Do I need a licence to fly a spray drone?	Yes. A remote pilot licence, held by the person flying, plus a UIN for the machine registered on Digital Sky.
How much is the licence?	The DGCA fee is Rs 100 and it is valid 10 years. The training course is the real cost, quoted between roughly Rs 15,000 and Rs 50,000 depending on the organisation.
Can I fly without permission over farmland?	Yes, in the green zone up to 400 feet, provided the machine is registered and the pilot is licensed. Check the airspace map for each new cluster.
What if my village is near an airport?	Within 8 to 12 km of an airport perimeter the ceiling drops to 200 feet, and above that you need air traffic control permission. Check before you quote the job.
Is insurance compulsory?	Third party insurance is required under Part X of the Drone Rules, with nano drones exempt. Buy hull cover too.
What happens if I have an accident?	Report it, keep the log, and let the insurer handle the claim. Flying without insurance turns a Rs 20,000 repair into a personal liability.

Operations and customers

Question	Answer
How many acres can one drone do in a day?	Physically 40 to 50, realistically 20 to 30 once water, chemical, charging and travel are counted. Plan on 20 until your own log says otherwise.
How much water does a spray need?	20 litres a hectare early season, 25 at full canopy, per the agriculture ministry SOP. Halving it to save trips is the most common cause of a failed spray.
Should I supply the chemical?	Not in year one. It adds a licence, credit risk and margin arguments to a business that is still learning to fly.

Question	Answer
What should I charge?	Rs 300 to Rs 700 an acre by crop and plot size, as a blended Rs 450 in the model. Never by the hour.
Will women SHG drones take my market?	They take the easy, subsidised, village-centre work. Partner with them for peak weeks instead of undercutting.
What is the biggest reason operators quit?	A six-month season against a twelve-month EMI, and no second service to fill the gap.

Risk

Question	Answer
What if a farmer claims crop damage?	Your spray log, your calibration record and your airspace note are the evidence. Offer a joint inspection within 48 hours and settle small claims fast; reputation travels faster than the drone.
What if the battery dies mid-spray?	It lands on its own if the failsafe is configured. Test the failsafe on day one, in an empty field, before you fly a customer's crop.
Can I fly in rain or high wind?	No. Stop at about 3 m/s wind, and do not fly in rain. Refusing a job is cheaper than a crash.
Is the machine insured against theft?	Only if your hull policy covers theft and you have declared the storage location. Check the wording.
What if the rules change?	They will. Read the transition clause of any amendment and keep your registration current; the 2024 aviation law and the 2025 draft drone bill are the two documents to watch.

The 30-day launch plan

Days	Do this	Output
1-3	Ride 15 km, count cropped land, talk to five farmers about what they pay for spraying	A one-page district verdict: go or no-go
4-6	Meet the District Agriculture Officer and the nearest KVK; ask whether Kisan Drones are in this year's plan	Written answer on subsidy availability
7-9	Get three written quotations for a 16 litre machine and three RPTO course quotes	Costed capex worksheet
10-12	Fill worksheets 2 to 4 with real numbers; compute break-even acres	A number you can defend
13-16	Book the RPTO course; start the Udyam registration; open a current account	Pilot training scheduled
17-20	Register as a service provider with the KVK and two input dealers; build the 40-name list	Pipeline started
21-24	Apply for the subsidy with the complete file, or record in writing why you are not eligible	Application or a documented decision
25-27	Buy the machine, register it for a UIN, buy insurance, test the failsafe in an empty field	Legal machine, tested
28-30	Run three free demos in three villages, announce one price, take the first two paid bookings	First revenue

Sources

Every figure in this book comes from one of the documents below, checked in November 2026. Where a number is a planning assumption rather than a published figure, the text says so.

Source	What it was used for
Sub-Mission on Agricultural Mechanization, Operational Guidelines, revised August 2026 (Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare)	Subsidy slabs, CHC and Farm Machinery Bank rules, the Rs 2,000 per hectare hiring support, training conditions, empanelment
Namo Drone Didi operational guidelines and PIB release, 1 November 2024	Rs 1,261 crore outlay, 14,500 SHGs, 80% support capped at Rs 8 lakh, AIF loan at 3% subvention, 15-day training, package contents
PIB release, 13 February 2026, on distribution of agricultural drones	1,094 drones distributed, 500 under the scheme, ADRTC findings on 7-8 minutes per acre and 5-20 minutes of flight per charge
PRS Legislative Research, Demands for Grants 2026-27 analysis	Budget provision movement from Rs 100 crore to Rs 677 crore
The Drone Rules, 2021 (G.S.R. 589(E), 25 August 2021) and the Ministry of Civil Aviation backgrounder	Size classes, UIN, remote pilot eligibility and fees, airspace zones, insurance under Part X, penalty ceiling, DGFT import regulation
Directorate General of Civil Aviation, Digital Sky platform	Airspace map, UIN registration, remote pilot licence process
Department of Agriculture standard operating procedure for drone application of pesticides, under the Insecticides Act framework	Height, speed, spray volume, droplet size, nozzle type, swath, wind, temperature and humidity limits
56th GST Council recommendations and CBIC material, September 2025	5% GST on drones from 22 September 2025
Haryana Authority for Advance Ruling, PI Industries matter	Spraying of agrochemicals on farmland as an exempt support service to agriculture under heading 9986
Dealer price lists and RPTO fee quotations, August to October 2026	Machine prices, battery and kit costs, training fee range, per-acre market rates

Glossary

Term	Meaning
UIN	Unique Identification Number issued for a drone on the Digital Sky platform
RPC / RPL	Remote pilot certificate issued by a training organisation, and the licence DGCA issues on its basis
RPTO	Remote Pilot Training Organisation authorised by DGCA to run the course
SMAM	Sub-Mission on Agricultural Mechanization, the scheme that pays part of the machine cost
CHC	Custom Hiring Centre, a registered service provider that rents machines to farmers
FPO	Farmer Producer Organisation, a collective that can apply for group slabs and buy services in bulk
AIF	Agriculture Infrastructure Fund, the lending route used for the SHG share in Namo Drone Didi
DBT	Direct Benefit Transfer, the route by which the Rs 2,000 per hectare support reaches the farmer
NPNT	No Permission No Takeoff, the digital authorisation layer for compliant drones

A last word

The people who make money from drone spraying in India are not the ones with the best machine. They are the ones who read the subsidy guidelines before buying, kept a spray log from the first day, and said no to work

that would not pay for the battery. None of that requires capital. It requires doing the boring part first.

If your district fails the ride test in the first three days of the plan, keep the money. There will be another season, and another window, and you will enter it with a better map than the person who bought on impulse.

This playbook is an educational guide. Subsidy rates, scheme windows, airspace boundaries and tax positions change. Verify every figure against the current government notification and take professional advice before committing capital.